China’s geostrategy is evolving and now includes a larger region both on land as well as at sea, exemplified through the Belt and Road Initiative, bringing China further into India’s neighbourhood. Notwithstanding that Sino–US naval rivalry in the East and South China Seas is at the heart of a new China–US bipolar world system, both the United States and China pay increasing attention to the larger Indo-Pacific strategic theatre. Even if China’s military strategy is likely to remain one of regional power projection, the contours of this region are expanding beyond East Asia and the South and East China Seas to include Central Asia and South Asia as well as the Indian Ocean.[98]

The Indian Ocean Region has gained in importance for Beijing over the last two decades along with China’s growing prominence in world trade, and China has since the mid-1990s moved from being a net exporter of crude oil to become the world’s number one importer, with half of its crude oil imported from the Middle East passing through the Indian Ocean.[99] Moreover, from 2008 onwards, China has participated in the international anti-piracy effort in the Gulf of Aden, sailing PLA Navy vessels through the Indian Ocean on a regular basis.[100] China also sends submarines to the Indian Ocean, ostensibly in support of its counterpiracy patrols.[101] A Chinese nuclear-powered attack submarine (SSN) made its first declared operational patrol in the Indian Ocean from December 2013 to February 2014, and in February 2017, a task force from the PLA Navy’s South Sea Fleet conducted an extended deployment to the Indian Ocean and Western Pacific.[102] In August 2017, China officially opened its first overseas military base in Djibouti, deploying a company of marines and equipment to the base. According to Chinese authorities, its Djibouti base will mainly support counterpiracy and humanitarian assistance and disaster relief (HADR) operations.[103] China is a long way from being able to project naval power into the Indian Ocean